

## **How I Fit into the Financial Services Profession**

From 2003 to 2013, I worked as an economics professor in Tokyo, at a university that primarily served graduate students who worked as government officials in developing and emerging market countries. My research during those years centered on public pension systems in countries such as Vietnam, Thailand, and Pakistan. My interest in finance was mostly prompted by managing my own personal finances, and reading books like *A Random Walk Down Wall Street* led me to become a passive investor with a focus on low costs and a long-term mind-set.

By 2009, I started to become serious about moving my family back to the United States. I started studying for the CFA examinations in 2009 as a way to make myself more marketable for US employers. In 2010, I obtained access to a data set that provided financial market returns from a variety of countries extending back to 1900. I don't recall exactly how I first came across William Bengen's 4 percent rule for retirement income, but I believe it was mentioned briefly in the CFA curriculum. I thought it could be interesting to see how the 4 percent rule would have performed in other countries and not just the United States. I finished an article on the topic in September 2010 as my first entry at my new Retirement Researcher blog and submitted it for review at the Journal of Financial Planning.

The article was published in December 2010. For a traditional academic, this publication was remarkable for two reasons. First, publication took place three months after submission, which is extremely fast compared to the academic world, where it could take journals one to three years to publish articles. Second, I received reader feedback, indicating that the article was actually being read and not just collecting dust on university library bookshelves. I was hooked and made a full transition from economics to personal financial planning. I published a number of additional research articles about retirement income in the Journal of Financial Planning in 2011 and 2012 and even won the journal's award for the most influential article published in 2011, while still living and working in Japan.